

Retention Exception Guidance

Guidance ID G-2026-12 | Version 1.0 | Internal working guidance | 2026-06-30

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Purpose

A decision process for temporarily retaining or deleting data outside the standard schedule when a documented legal, regulatory, or operational exception applies.

Scope and boundary

Matter Alpha example: an exception affecting the 42 preservation-target records must be submitted by 2026-07-12. An exception is narrow, time-bound, and reviewable.

Rule summary

A retention exception is permitted only for a defined basis, limited dataset, and fixed duration. It must not override preservation, extend by inertia, or convert an operational convenience into indefinite retention.

Decision path

Step	Required action
1	Describe the exception Identify records, system, normal disposition, specific reason, owner, and requested end date.
2	Check conflicts Confirm whether a legal hold, regulator request, security investigation, or contract condition changes the proposed action.
3	Limit the scope Apply the smallest dataset, shortest practical duration, and least-privileged access.
4	Approve and review Records Management and Privacy Legal record the decision; Counsel reviews extensions before expiration.

Operating controls

Escalation trigger

Escalate if a request would override Matter Alpha preservation, retain sensitive data without a clear basis, or continue past 2026-07-12 without an approved extension.

Recordkeeping

Keep the request, basis note, scope inventory, approval, technical setting, review date, extension rationale, and deletion confirmation.

Roles and cadence

Business owner supplies complete facts and implements controls. Privacy Legal verifies the review path, decision rationale, and escalation. Records Management maintains retention evidence. Reassess on a material change, a new recipient or system, a control failure, or the scheduled annual review.

Fictional source register

Reference	Fictional use
Aurora Federation Privacy Framework, 2026 edition	Synthetic baseline for purpose limitation, accountability, and transfer review.
Harbor State Information Stewardship Rules, guidance note 4	Synthetic comparison point for notification, processor, and records controls.
Aster Legal Matter Alpha control register, 2026-06-30	Synthetic operational anchor for preservation target 42 and exception workflow.

Decision record minimum

Record the request or event, scope, facts relied upon, rule path, decision maker, conditions, escalation outcome, review date, and storage location. Do not include personal data, credentials, or privileged source material in this guidance record.